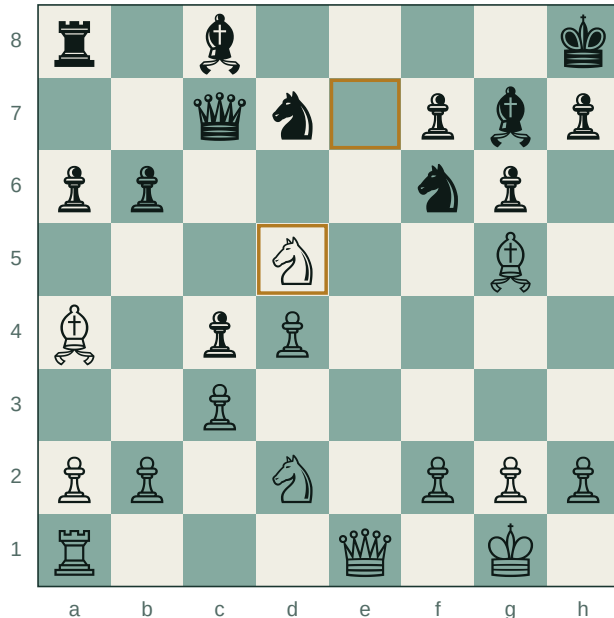


Loose-piece tactics: Black, move 17

Loose-piece tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 17.Nxd5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

17...Nxd5 18. Qe8+ Nf8

17...Nxd5 The knight captures the knight on d5. Recorded reply: **18.Qe8+**.

18...Nf8 The knight moves from d7 to f8.

At the end, nominal material is White 30 / Black 32 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +3:** the balance goes from -1 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on g1. Geometrically undefended: bishop on g5 and knight on d5. Check for tactical protection.